

STORYBEAT: APP SUMMARY & WORKFLOW

Core Premise:

StoryBeat is an AI-assisted mobile-first story outlining and timeline tool. The user builds structured narratives by answering story prompts, locking canon facts, exploring alternate versions, and gradually surfacing a canonical 12-beat arc — or multiple branches of it.

STRUCTURE MODEL

Hierarchy (Zoomable & Clickable)

- **Act** → contains one or more **Sequences**
- **Sequence** → contains multiple **Scenes**
- **Scene** → contains multiple **Beats**
- **Beat** → smallest narrative unit; may contain sub-beats or alternates

Core Beats (The 12 Beats):

- These define the default outline structure that all stories ultimately resolve to:
 1. **Where We Begin** – The world and character status quo
 2. **What They Want** – The protagonist's initial desire or goal
 3. **The World Around Them** – Obstacles, tensions, and external pressures
 4. **Something Goes Wrong** – The first major disruption or inciting event
 5. **A Hard Choice** – A dilemma or personal risk the protagonist must face
 6. **Crossing the Line** – A decision or action that can't be undone
 7. **Things Get Messy** – Complications, resistance, collateral damage
 8. **A Truth Is Revealed** – A revelation that reframes the story's stakes
 9. **Everything Starts to Fall Apart** – Momentum toward collapse
 10. **The Lowest Point** – Loss, failure, or confrontation
 11. **Becoming Someone New** – Transformation or insight
 12. **How It All Ends** – Resolution: internal and external closure
- These 12 beats anchor all versions and branches of the story, even when told out of order or nonlinearly.

Navigation:

- Timeline is **zoomable** (high-level → granular)
- Timeline is **click-through** (tap Act to view Sequences → Scenes → Beats)
- Full flat timeline toggle *TBD* (likely deferred)

TIMELINE + BRANCHES

- One primary timeline
- Forks allowed from **any beat**
- Forks inherit all content **up to** that beat
- After fork, timeline is a clean slate (unless user copies content)
- Max forks per project: 7
- Forks are:
 - Auto-named ("Fork from Beat 9")
 - User-renamable
 - Non-mergeable in v1
 - Viewable **side-by-side** for comparison

BEAT SEMANTICS

- Beats are expandable cards with:
 - Editable title
 - Static number (can be renamed)
 - Summary text (user/AI generated)
 - Tags: characters, locations, tone, etc.
 - Lock status (full beat / partial / fact)
 - Parent lineage (scene ID, fork origin)
 - Sub-beats (optional)
 - AI regeneration history / alternatives
- Beats respect locked canon across project
- Beat alternates → **new branches**, not in-place suggestions

CHARACTER & STORY BIBLE

- Canonical data includes:
 - Characters
 - World elements
 - Relationships
 - Traits
 - Rules / facts
- **Bible exists at project level** and applies across all timelines
- Canon is:
 - Editable manually
 - **Inferred** from user input or locked beats
- Changes to Bible:
 - Affect downstream AI behavior
 - May prompt review of affected beats

Bidirectional Flow:

- New beats → trigger prompts to add to Bible
- Updated Bible → modifies AI's beat generation

RULES, LOCKS & CONSTRAINT NEGOTIATION

Locking Granularity:

- Users can lock:
 - Full beat
 - Paragraph
 - Individual fact

Canon Violation Workflow:

1. AI proposes new idea
2. Internal pass checks it against locked canon
3. If conflicts:
 - Alert user
 - Suggest unlocks or alternatives
4. If change is accepted:
 - Flag downstream beats as "requires review"
5. Autofix / Alert-only toggle (per user/project)

AI Negotiation:

- When overly constrained, AI may say:
"Unlocking X would open up new narrative options. Want to proceed?"

PROJECT DATA MODEL

Project Includes:

- Metadata (title, genre, format)
- Story Bible
- All timelines:
 - Main
 - Forks (with origin points)
- Each timeline:
 - Acts → Sequences → Scenes → Beats
- Beats contain:
 - Summary, sub-beats, status, AI history, locks
- Pitch Package (logline, short synopsis, one-sheet)
- Import/export data
- Notes, tags, file history

AI BEHAVIOR

Model Assignment:

- **Claude 4.5 Sonnet**: heavy tasks (12/24-beat generation, pitch, transform)
- **GPT-4 mini / GPT-5.2 mini**: refinement, summaries, AI alternatives

AI Prompt Structure:

- Inputs: locked canon, last 2–3 beats, characters, tone, project context
- Output: beat-level text, scene summaries, pitch elements

Surprise Me:

- AI mutates only **unlocked** elements
- Proposes alternatives if too constrained
“With current constraints, here’s what’s possible. Want to loosen any?”

Rewrite Tools:

- “Rewrite Act II” → AI rewrites all **unlocked** beats
- “Add twist” → AI finds valid point of tension or reversal
- “Improve pacing” → AI reorders or rephrases unlocked beats

UX DESIGN & INTERACTIONS

Timeline Interaction:

- Scroll/zoom timeline view
- Tap to expand Acts → Scenes → Beats
- Side-by-side timeline comparison view
- Fork from any beat
- View AI alternatives in-place

Beat Interaction:

- Expand
- Lock/unlock
- Regenerate (surprise me, alternate versions)
- Tag (characters, locations, tone, etc.)
- Open lineage (see fork history or beat ancestry)

Project Management:

- Library of projects
- Each project contains multiple timelines, story bible, pitch packages
- Search by beat title, tags, character, fork ID

Import/Export:

- Export full project, including:

- All timelines
- Characters
- Canon rules
- Pitch package
- Support for DOCX, PDF, Fountain/FDX (future)

DESIGN PRINCIPLES

- User-Directed, AI-Supported:
 - AI does not dictate the story
 - Reject/edit/accept is the core loop
- Constraint-Driven Creativity:
 - Locked canon defines the creative sandbox
 - AI can suggest “if-then” possibilities
- Multiverse Drafting:
 - Timelines are alternate *narrative outcomes*, not overwritten versions
 - User navigates and compares all variations inside one Project
- Emergent Bible:
 - Characters, facts, relationships discovered *through* outlining
 - No rigid wiki — fluid sync between beats and canon
- Surprise with Coherence:
 - AI randomness is shaped by rules, tone, and past decisions
 - Surprise = valid variation, not chaos

Glossary of StoryBeat Terms

Term	Definition
<i>Project</i>	A container for a full story idea and all its branches, characters, and timelines
<i>Timeline</i>	A single narrative path through a story (main or alternate)
<i>Fork</i>	A timeline branch diverging from a specific beat
<i>Act</i>	A major structural segment of the story
<i>Sequence</i>	A subdivision of an act (cluster of scenes)
<i>Scene</i>	A concrete narrative moment or dramatic unit
<i>Beat</i>	The smallest narrative block; may contain a micro-action or emotional turn
<i>Sub-Beat</i>	A further breakdown inside a beat (optional)
<i>Locked Beat</i>	A beat (or element of a beat) that cannot be changed by the AI
<i>Canon</i>	All facts or beats locked into place by the user
<i>Story Bible</i>	A persistent document containing characters, relationships, world rules, facts, and history
<i>MacGuffin</i>	A story object or goal driving plot momentum (stored in the Bible)
<i>Constraint</i>	A rule or locked element the AI must not violate
<i>Surprise Me</i>	An AI-driven creative shake-up of a beat or story section, limited by current constraints

<i>Alternate Beat</i>	A possible beat variant offered by the AI (must be accepted or forked to exist)
<i>Pitch Package</i>	A compiled presentation of the story: logline, synopsis, one-sheet
<i>Frame</i>	A narrative wrapper (e.g., Prologue, Epilogue) that is optional and outside the core beat structure
<i>Transform</i>	A change in format (e.g., Book to TV series) applied to a story/timeline
<i>Constraint Negotiation</i>	When the AI offers trade-offs ("Unlock this fact to explore new story paths")
<i>AI Pass</i>	A reasoning step where the AI checks for logic breaks or canon violations
<i>Alternate Timeline</i>	A new draft of the story diverging from a specific beat onward
<i>Zoomable Timeline</i>	The UI model that allows navigation from Acts all the way down to Beats